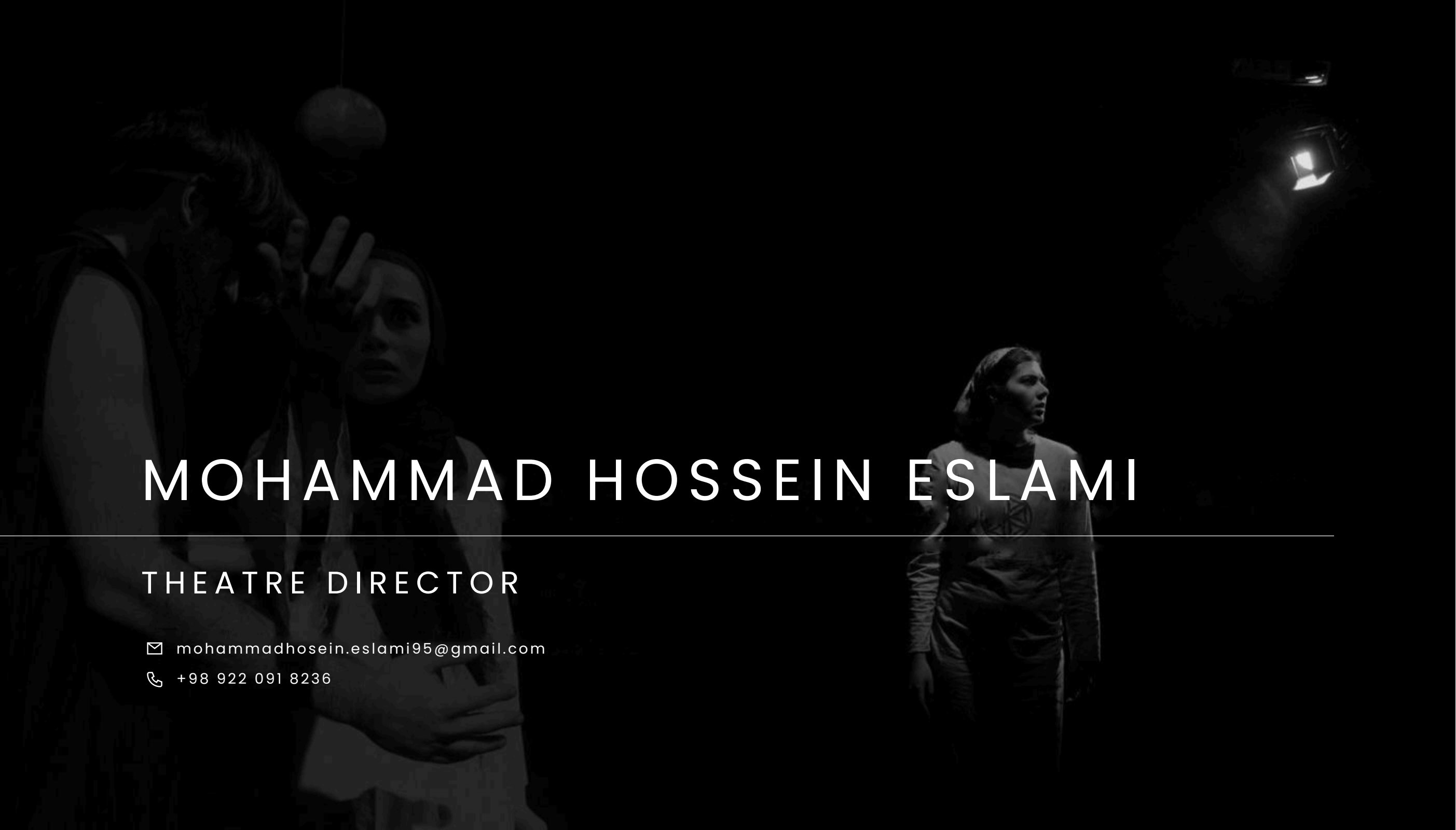




MOHAMMAD HOSSEIN ESLAMI

THEATRE DIRECTOR

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ABOUT

Mohammad Hossein Eslami

I am a theatre director based in Tehran. I hold an MA in Theatre Directing from Tehran University of Art, where my thesis studied the representation of identity in the work of Elizabeth LeCompte and my practical thesis was *Maid to Marry*. I also hold a BSc in Software Engineering from Shahid Beheshti University.

My work moves between text-based theatre, devised ensemble work, live music, contemporary dance and media. My research interests are postdramatic theatre, intermediality, political theatre, and gender and queer studies.

I am currently directing, producing and designing the set for *Mephisto For Ever*, based on Tom Lanoye's play and Klaus Mann's novel, which opens in November 2026.

EDUCATION	MA Theatre Directing, Tehran University of Art (2019–2023) BSc Software Engineering, Shahid Beheshti University (2013–2018)
DIRECTING	Mephisto For Ever (2026) · Maid to Marry (2023) · King Lear (2021) · The Proposal (2020) · In Front of City Theater (2018) · Asgardia (2016)
DESIGN	Mixed Sandwich, media (2024) · The Good Person of Szechwan, set (2022)
PERFORMING	Saturday Nights (2017) · A Requiem for Oedipus (2015)

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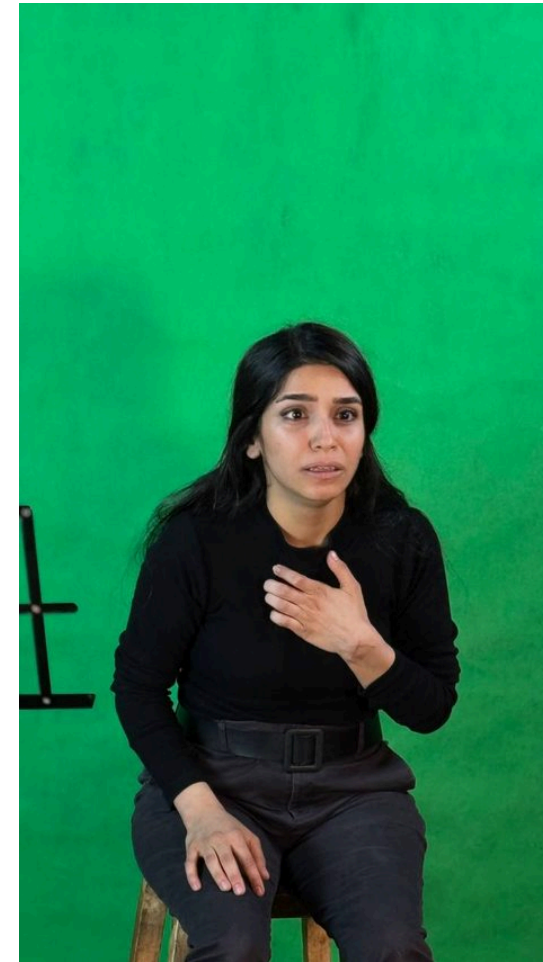
Mephisto For Ever

Director, Producer & Scene Designer

Based on Tom Lanoye's play and Klaus Mann's novel
Mephisto

— IN REHEARSAL · OPENING NOVEMBER 2026

Mephisto For Ever follows an actor who makes a deal with power so he can stay on stage. At its heart is a simple, uncomfortable question: what is left of art once beauty starts working for those in control? Our dramaturgical research moves between Goethe's *Faust*, its appropriation by Nazi cultural policy, and the life of Gustaf Gründgens. We want *Mephisto* to appear not as a devil who comes from outside, but as something already living inside the artist.

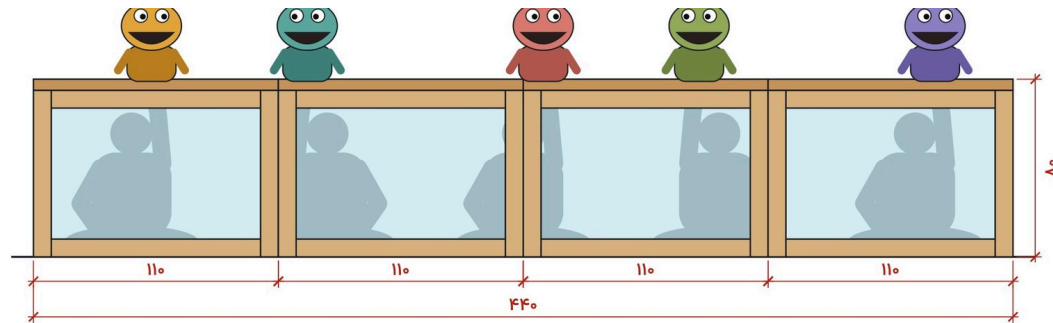
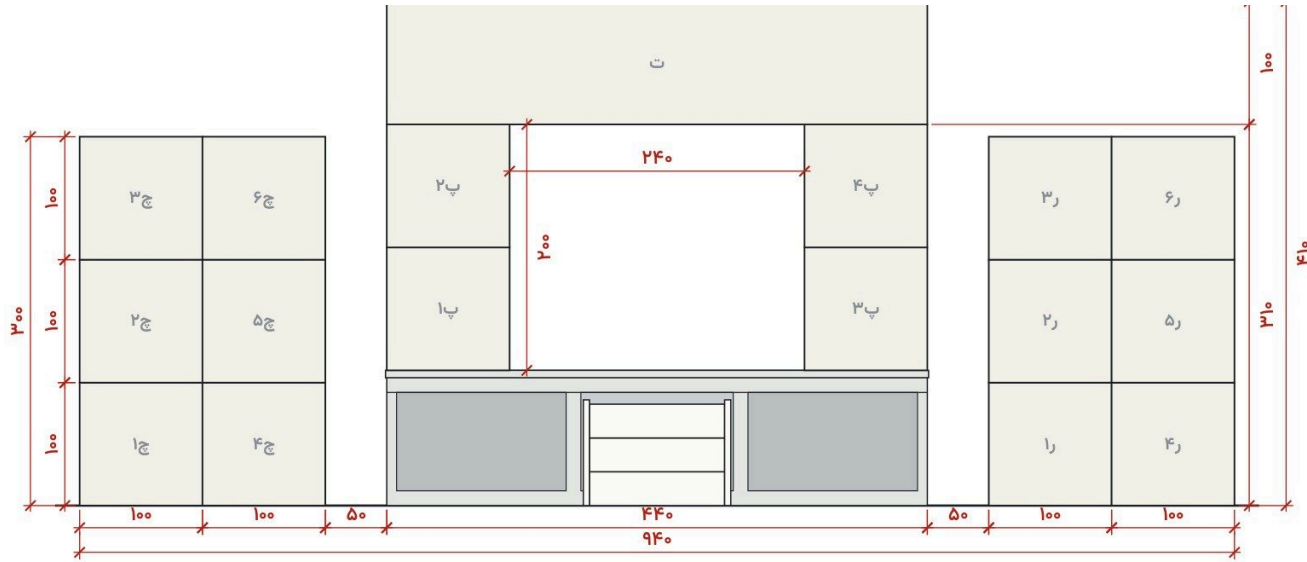


The production uses the carnival-like nature of a theatre company, framed as metatheatrical: a troupe performing itself. Classical, modern, puppetry and contemporary dance sit side by side. Scenes of power are carried mostly by bodies, distance and image rather than words. The costumes decay across five stages, and their palette is designed together with the video mapping.

ROLE	Director, Producer & Scene Designer
TEXT	Tom Lanoye, <i>Mephisto For Ever</i>
NOVEL	Klaus Mann, <i>Mephisto</i>
STATUS	In rehearsal
OPENING	November 2026



What is left of art
once beauty starts working
for those in control?



Set & Puppet Stage

I am also designing the set. It is built from sixteen one-metre cubes, a 4.4-metre arch beam and a stepped platform, in pine, chicken wire and papier-mâché.

Puppetry is one of the languages of the production. The puppet stage is a row of four identical frames of timber and clear plexiglass, 4.4 metres long in all.

SET	16 one-metre cubes · 4.4 m arch beam · stepped platform · 9.4 × 4.1 m overall
PUPPETS	4 frames, 110 × 80 × 32 cm each, 4.4 m in all
MATERIALS	Pine, chicken wire, papier-mâché · timber, plexiglass, plywood



3D PREVISUALISATION (PREVIS PRO): KURT AND NICOLE · KURT AND REBEKKA



I previsualise key scenes in 3D.

Below: photographs from rehearsals, with ribbons, shadow play and inverted bodies.



In Front of City Theater

DIRECTOR · CO-SCENE DESIGNER | 2018 | NEAUPHLE-LE-CHÂTEAU THEATER, TEHRAN

In Front of City Theater is based on a true story: the life of Sohrab A'raabi, a victim of the political turmoil around the Green Movement and Iran's 2009 election. The play is divided into four episodes, each centred on a different character closely connected to Sohrab; through their narratives, Sohrab's fate unfolds.

The text, by Salman Alighardashi, draws on classical Persian literature, including the epic myth of Rostam and Sohrab from the *Shahnameh*.



The project took a year, with a group of fifteen, six of them actors. One episode is built on choreography inspired by my contemporary dance classes: two actors play two sides of the same character, Zohreh, Sohrab's lover, and the scene draws on Pina Bausch's trust dance.



Photo : Mohammad Golmohammadi





The performance uses live music. Five tracks were composed during rehearsals, blending alternative rock with Persian folk music. The lyrics come from Mehdi Akhavan-Sales's poetry collection *The Ending of the Shahnameh*.

The music was there to strengthen the dramatic impact and draw the audience into the story.



Photo : Davush adhami

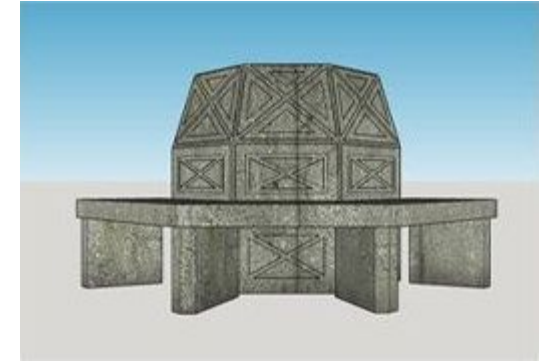
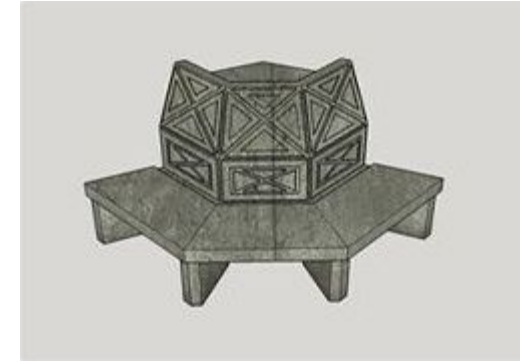
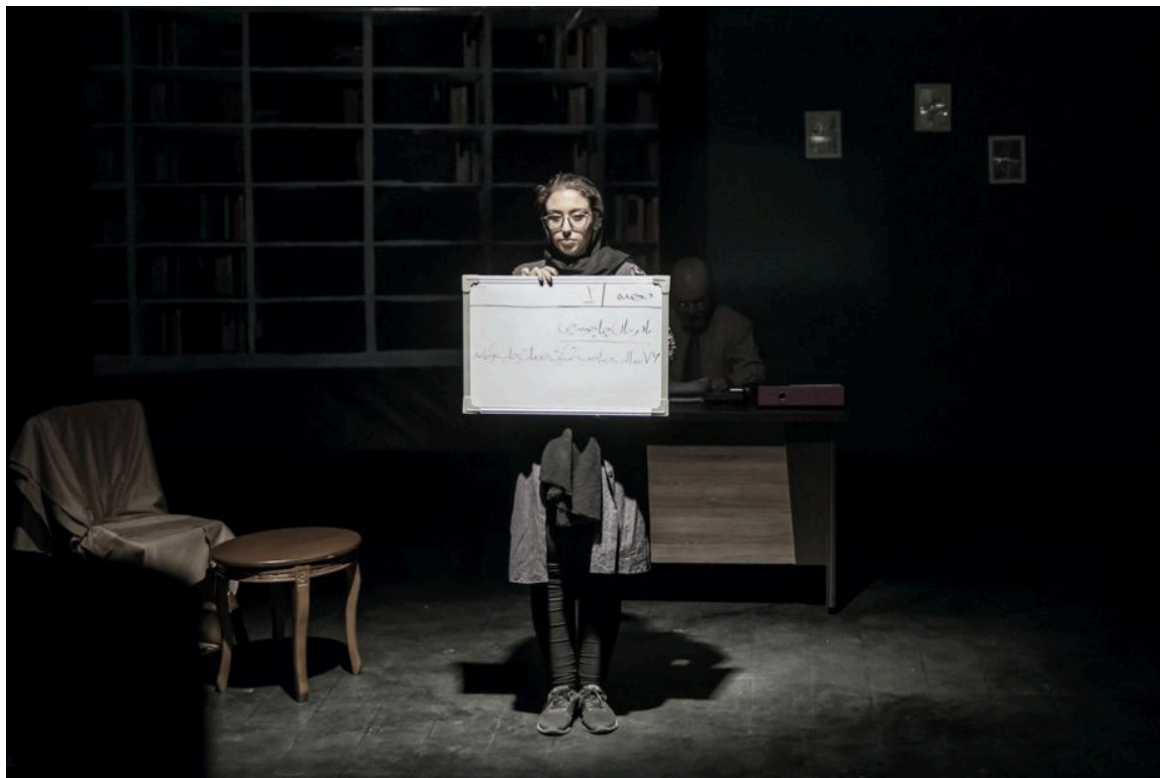


Photo : Davush adhami

I co-designed the set with Mohsen Khamechian. We started from 3D children's books, as a way of showing the chapters of Sohrab's life unfolding: a metal structure like turning book pages, with each scene bringing out its own objects. Designing and building it was a considerable challenge, and I learned a great deal from it.



Maid to Marry

DIRECTOR · MA PRACTICAL THESIS | 2023 | TEHRAN UNIVERSITY OF ART

Maid to Marry was my practical MA thesis in directing, supervised by Prof. Esmail Shafiee. It is based on Eugène Ionesco's short absurdist play about identity; we added a second subject, education.

The dramaturgy, developed with Mehdi Sharifi, uses other texts and a set of technical devices as mediators. Three performances run at the same time: a symbolic "cyber" version of the script on monitors; the play itself on stage; and seven teenagers, performers rather than actors, who play board games and narrate their day.



The approach grew out of my research on Elizabeth LeCompte, the basis of my theoretical thesis. Following her methods, we staged an existing play while bringing in completely different material, which gave the original text a polyphonic telling, treating it as raw material for the final script.

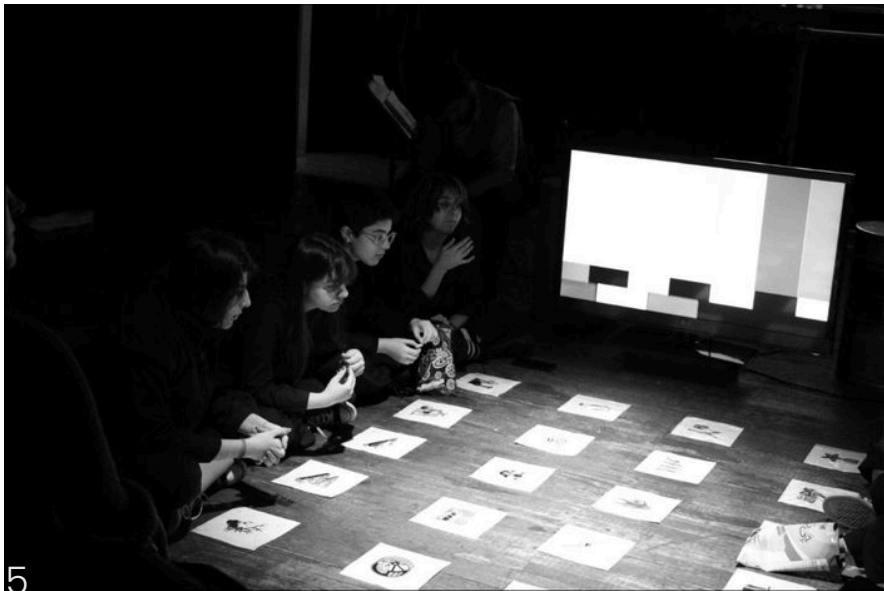
Everyone in the group proposed ideas, and whatever fitted the project went in. I saw my role as reshaping the ideas that came out of rehearsals rather than holding on to a plan made in advance. It gave me a new outlook on making work, and taught me to approach first ideas with some scepticism.







Much of the work was about the difference between an actor and a performer: the actors played their roles in several styles, and we had to be clear about the line between dramatic and non-dramatic moments. The two main characters were played by four actors, through both the technological mediators and live scenes, which needed careful coordination between the actors and the technology.





Asgardia

DIRECTOR · CO-PLAYWRIGHT | 2016 | MASHAYEKHI THEATER HALL,
TEHRAN

Asgardia, co-written with Reyhane Yazdani, takes its name from Asgardia, the first country in space. Six strangers from different social backgrounds are handpicked by a corporation for a mission to Asgardia. Inside the spaceship they face conflicts, challenges and their own desires.

Alongside this runs a mythic line drawn from the story of Adam and Eve in the Old Testament, which looks for the roots of human conflict at the beginning of existence and shows it as a cycle.





Asgardia was my first professional production as a director. We started with only an idea and built a theatre group from scratch, through training and development.



The company contributed ideas, which we, as playwrights, used to structure the story. The whole process took fourteen months.



It was a low-budget production, and managing costs was one of the main challenges. Most of the eleven actors were performing professionally for the first time, which helped me develop my skills in working with a large ensemble.

The structure is episodic, with two lines running in parallel. The spaceship scenes are played realistically; between them, scenes outside time and place use dance and choreography to produce a *Verfremdungseffekt*, a distancing effect.



The Proposal

DIRECTOR | 2020 | TEHRAN UNIVERSITY OF ART | ANTON CHEKHOV

The Proposal, after Anton Chekhov, was my final project for the Principles of Directing course in my MA, supervised by Prof. Esmaeil Shafiee. The challenge was to keep strictly to the original text, with no additions or cuts, while bringing our own tone and style to the staging.





We analysed Chekhov's text closely with the actors, researched commedia dell'arte, and brought its gestures into our interpretation. Working with a classical Russian text and with Chekhov was new for me.



King Lear

DIRECTOR · 2021 · TEHRAN UNIVERSITY OF ART

King Lear was my final project for the Advanced Directing 2 course in my MA, led by Prof. Esmaeil Shafiee. The task was to choose and stage the play's most important scenes; we focused on the scene in which Lear curses his own children in the barren desert.

With limited resources, we made eight versions of the scene, each emphasising different directorial elements such as lighting, staging and mise-en-scène, and combined the best ideas in the final performance. It taught me to pay attention to scenes that seem minor; they often hold the key to understanding a play.

Other Projects

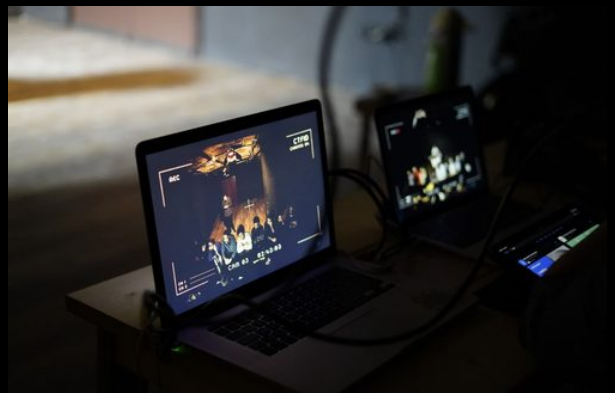
Actor · Scene Designer · Media



Mixed Sandwich

Media Producer & Media Projection Coordinator

An alternative underground production, staged independently without an official performance permit. Directed by Mohammad Hossein Heshmati and Aref Hassanzadeh, November 2024. I was responsible for producing the media content and coordinating the projection during the performance.



The Good Person of Szechwan

Scene Designer · Dir. Masoud Jahandideh · 2022

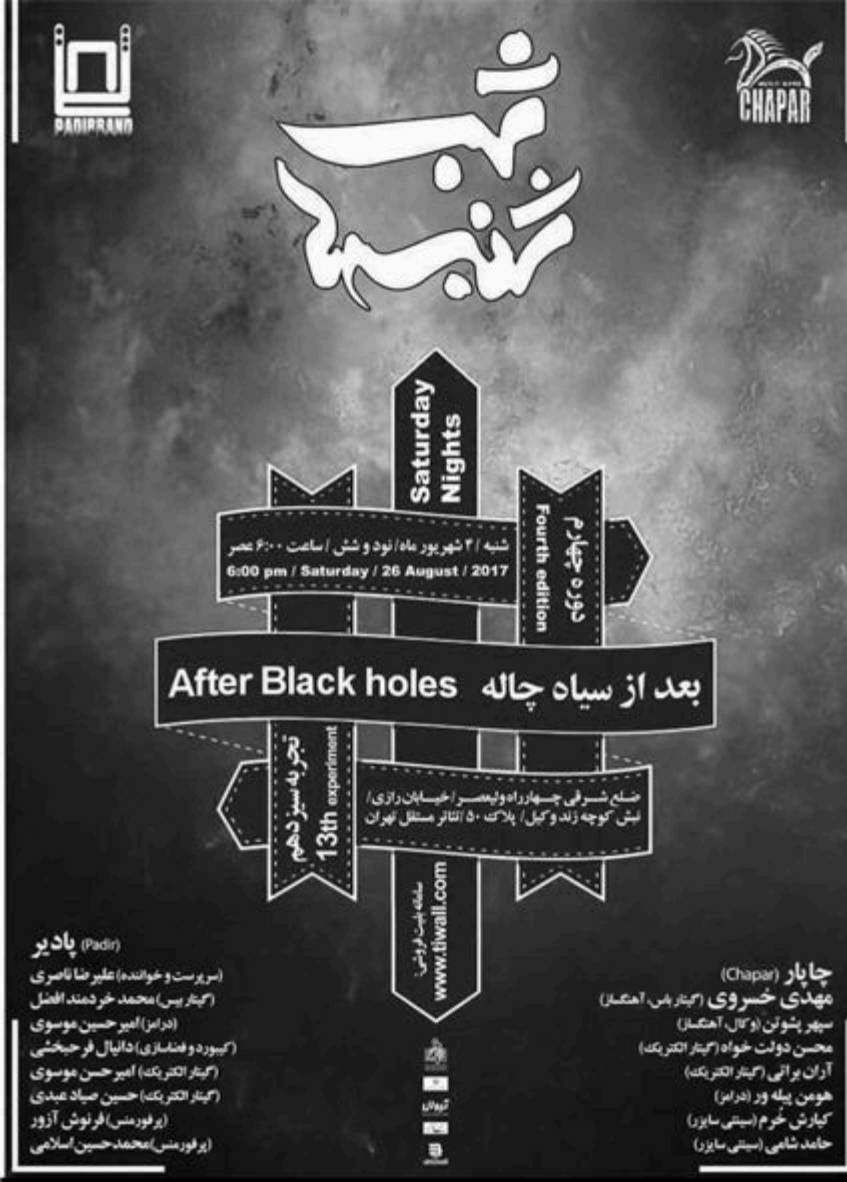


I designed the set for Bertolt Brecht's *The Good Person of Szechwan*, directed by Masoud Jahandideh at the Mehregan Theater in Tehran (2022).

My focus was the stage floor. To bring out the connection between the actors' movements and the ground, I designed a wooden floor that produced sounds when the actors moved on it in specific ways. Getting the notes we wanted depended on careful placement of the floor's frame.

Scene changes were fast and happened in front of the audience, so the props had to be light and easy for the actors to carry. Working as set designer on a production that had been in rehearsal for months gave me, as a director, a closer understanding of the cast's perspective.





Saturday Nights

Saturday Nights was a weekly series at the Independent Theater of Tehran that introduced new rock and metal bands. The band Padir wanted more than a concert, and asked us to design and stage a full performance. With Farnoosh Azor, I choreographed eight dance pieces and two short plays, placed between the songs. Performing in it broadened my understanding of how music, movement and visual elements work together.

A Requiem for Oedipus was a student production at Shahid Beheshti University, made with the university's theatre association and philosophy society and directed by Abtin Gholampour. I played one of the chorus members. After researching the chorus in Sophocles' plays, we reduced it to four performers. It was my first production at the university, and a lesson in perseverance and teamwork.

A Requiem for Oedipus

Actor (Chorus) · 2015



طراح و کارگردان: آبتین غلامپور
دستیار کارگردان: گلنار مقدم
مدیر پروژه: فرنوش آزور
دستیار نور و صدا: رضا یوسف دوست

سوزگوارهای برای لانتیسوس

بسم الله الرحمن الرحیم

علیرضا رضایی
هلیا امامی ال اقا
سینا امامی نیا
محسن خامه چیان
رضوان جهانبخش
محمد حسین اسلامی
مریم عبد اللهی
گلنار مقدم
تیرداد برقی
بیثا محمد حسینی
محمد خباز
راضیه سادات عقیلی
پریسا جهانپور
اشکان یار احمدی
آبتین غلامپور
فرنوش آزور
سعید چراغعلی
فاطمه نیایش نیا

با تشکر از:
نوید گرگین (دبیر انجمن علمی فلسفه دانشگاه شهید بهشتی)،
مسعود جهانپوده (دبیر کانون تناتر دانشگاه شهید بهشتی)،
حسن فرضی پور، مرتضی غلامی، آقای دبیری، خانم ملک
شیخی، امیر عسگری، فاضل سیاره، رایحه حسینی و تمامی
عزیزانی که ما را در به ثمر رسیدن این پروژه یاری رسانده اند و
می رسانند و نامشان اینجا آورده نشده است!

کاری مشترک از انجمن علمی فلسفه و کانون تناتر دانشگاه شهید بهشتی
معاونت فرهنگی و امور دانشجویی دانشگاه شهید بهشتی
بهار نود و چهار

صفحه ی اینستاگرام کانون تناتر Kanun_taatr

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